HackGlobal 2026 | Hacker Guide

Welcome to HackGlobal

HackGlobal is a global online hackathon by Polaris School of Technology, co-powered by Vultr, with builders from 28 countries and 7 partner universities. The kickoff is on the evening of 13 November, and hacking runs for 36 hours, from 00:00 IST on 14 November to 12:00 IST on 15 November 2026. This guide has everything you need to build, get help and submit.

Key links

What	Link
Official website	hackglobal.polariscampus.com
Discord (all updates and support)	discord.gg/b5FBUbsh
Vultr Community (check-in and submission)	community.vultr.com/e/hackglobal-2026
Starter kit (GitHub)	github.com/shubhamupadhyay-pixel/hackglobal-starter
Support email	events@polariscampus.com

Schedule

Hacking runs for 36 hours for everyone, from Sat 14 Nov, 00:00 IST to Sun 15 Nov, 12:00 IST. All times below are IST (UTC+5:30). The schedule on the website shows every session in your own time zone.

Key moments

When (IST)	What happens
Fri 13 Nov, evening	Check-in opened on Vultr Community. Still open: if you're joining late, check in as soon as you join
Fri 13 Nov, 20:30 to 22:30	HackGlobal kickoff ceremony
Sat 14 Nov, 00:00	Hack begins
Sat 14 Nov, 21:45 to 22:30	Open Q&A

When (IST)	What happens
Sun 15 Nov, 03:30 to 05:00	Mentor session 2
Sun 15 Nov, 10:30 to 20:30	Judging
Sun 15 Nov, 12:00	Hack ends: submissions close
Sun 15 Nov, 21:30 to 23:30	Project demos

Can't watch the kickoff live? A replay streams on Sat 14 Nov, 05:40 to 07:30 IST. The full live stream schedule, including mentor sessions and fun events, is posted on Discord.

Where everything happens

From here on, everything happens on two platforms: Discord and Vultr Community. Make sure every team member has joined both.

About HackCulture: HackCulture has no further role. If you submitted your idea there, you're good to go. Ignore any later stages shown on HackCulture.

Platform	Use it for
Discord (HackGlobal 2026)	Announcements, team formation, mentor help, all support, live stream updates
Vultr Community	Event registration, check-in and project submission

Teams

You can build solo or in a team. Teams can have 1 to 5 members.

- **Finding teammates:** post in the team-formation channel on Discord with your role, skills and time zone.
- **Cross-university teams:** teams with members from different universities get bonus points, which improves your odds in the final round.
- **Non-technical builders welcome:** designers, product thinkers and domain experts are valuable. You don't need a CS background.
- **Team changes:** teams are locked now that hacking has started, so no changes are possible.

Themes and tracks

There are four tracks, all built around applied AI and real-world impact. Non-technical teammates are welcome in every track.

Track	What it's about	Sample ideas
Agentic and GenAI apps	Agents that plan and act for people	Syllabus-to-study-plan agent, scholarship matcher, startup-in-a-box
Multimodal and accessibility	Voice, vision and translation tools that make technology usable by more people	Live captioner, document-to-form filler, voice-first app
Grounded knowledge and RAG	Assistants that answer from real sources and cite them	Ask-your-textbook tool, rights explainer, research helper
Civic and real-world impact	Everyday problems in a city or community	Issue reporter, misinformation checker, advisory bot for farmers or small businesses

Resources

HackGlobal is co-powered by Vultr, our main technology partner. You also get credits from Wispr Flow and Exa, plus a starter kit to save setup time.

Who gets credits: credits go only to teams that have joined Discord, joined Vultr Community and checked in. If any step is missing or not updated, we won't send credits to that team.

Credit	What you get	How to get it
Vultr	$200 per participant	Fill the Vultr credits form
Wispr Flow	Wispr Flow Pro free for 3 months	Promo code **POLTECH26** (steps below)
Exa	$20 free credits	Register on Exa and the credits are added to your account

Didn't get your credits? Check that every team member has joined Discord, joined Vultr Community and checked in. If all three are done, ask in the Discord server.

Vultr credits and setup

Every participant gets **$200 in Vultr credits**, free. Use them for Compute instances, Managed Databases, Kubernetes clusters or any other Vultr service during the hackathon.

Before you start: use an email address that has never been linked to a Vultr account. Use the same account for Vultr Community so everything stays in one place.

1. **Create a Vultr account.** Go to the Vultr registration page, enter your email and a strong password, accept the Terms of Service and Privacy Policy, and click **Create Free Account**.
2. **Verify your email.** Open the email from Vultr and click **Verify Your E-mail**. You'll land in the Vultr Console.
3. **Join Vultr Community and check in** (see How to submit).
4. **Claim your credits.** Fill the Vultr credits form to get your $200 in Vultr credits.

Your credits and account stay active through the event. To keep your deployments running after that, add a payment method in the Billing section.

Getting started with your first deployment: follow the Deploy on Vultr guide in the starter kit.

Questions about Vultr? Ask in the Discord server.

Wispr Flow and Exa credits

Wispr Flow

Welcome to Wispr Flow! We're excited to partner with Polaris School of Technology to bring you Wispr Flow Pro, completely free for 3 months.

Wispr Flow is a voice-to-text AI that turns your speech into clear, polished writing in any app. Whether you're writing emails, drafting assignments, taking notes or messaging, just speak and Flow does the rest.

How to redeem your free 3 months:

1. Download Wispr Flow on your desktop (Mac or Windows) from wisprflow.ai.
2. Open the app and go to **Billing**.
3. Scroll down to the promo code section and enter **POLTECH26**.

Exa

Exa is an AI-powered web search API, useful for research and agent projects. Register on the Exa platform to get $20 in free credits.

Starter kit (GitHub)

The HackGlobal starter kit gives you ready-to-use templates so you can start building in minutes. Link: [hackglobal-starter on GitHub](#).

1. Open the starter kit repo and click **Use this template** to make your own copy.
2. Pick the template folder that fits your project.
3. Follow the README in that folder to run it locally.
4. Deploy it on Vultr using the deploy guide in the repo.

What's inside: three templates (an AI chat app, a web research agent using Exa, and a Streamlit demo), a step-by-step Vultr deploy guide, a project README template and a submission checklist. Using it is optional. You can build in any stack.

To run the templates you need an AI API key from any OpenAI-compatible provider. The starter kit's README explains the options.

Mentors and help

All support happens in the HackGlobal 2026 Discord server. Mentors and organizers will help you there throughout the hackathon. Mentor session timings: Sat 14 Nov, 12:30 to 14:00 IST and Sun 15 Nov, 03:30 to 05:00 IST (see the schedule on the website for your local time).

How to ask for help (copy this into the help channel)

- What you're building, in one line
- The problem you're stuck on
- What you already tried
- Link to your repo or a screenshot of the error

For anything that isn't technical (teams, rules, submissions), ask in the help-desk channel or email events@polariscampus.com.

How to submit

All projects are submitted on Vultr Community, where HackGlobal 2026 registration and submissions are managed. HackCulture is only for your idea, so don't submit your project there. Submissions close on 15 November at 12:00 IST (see Schedule).

Step 1: Join Vultr Community

1. Open [community.vultr.com](#) and click the profile icon in the top-right corner.

2. **Sign In** with your Vultr account, or **Sign Up** for a new one. Use the same account you used to claim credits.
3. Click **Send Confirmation Email**, open the email titled "[Vultr Community] Confirm your email address" and click **Confirm email address**. Then return and click **Continue**.
4. Fill in the onboarding form (name, country, state, city), tick the checkbox and click **Accept & Continue**, then **Explore Community**.

Community points you see on the platform are part of Vultr Community. They don't count toward HackGlobal judging.

Step 2: Register and check in

1. Open the **Community** menu and select **Events**.
2. Find **HackGlobal 2026** (under All Events if it isn't featured) and click **Register now**.
3. Click **Save my spot**. You'll get notified about every event update.
4. **Check in:** on Fri 13 Nov evening, the **Check in** button goes live on the hackathon page. Every team member must check in before hacking begins. This is also how you unlock your Vultr credits.

Step 3: Submit your project

After you check in, click **Submit your build**. Every teammate needs a Vultr Community account.

Keep these ready before you open the form

- [ ] Project name and a one or two sentence description
- [ ] Architecture screenshots or a diagram showing how your project is built
- [ ] Industry or domain of your project
- [ ] Public GitHub repo link, with setup instructions and documentation
- [ ] Live demo URL (deployed on Vultr)
- [ ] Tech stack (languages, frameworks, tools)
- [ ] Overview: the problem, the use case and how it works
- [ ] How you used Vultr (for example, the Compute instance that hosts your backend)
- [ ] Teammates' names, emails or Vultr Community usernames

In the form, add the tag **Hackathons**, and under **Build for an event?** select **HackGlobal 2026**. Then click **Submit Project**. Without the event selected, your project won't show up on the hackathon page.

After you submit: a moderator reviews your project. Once approved, it appears on the Project Showcase page and the HackGlobal 2026 hackathon page. Standout projects may be featured.

Submit early. No submissions are accepted after the deadline. All deadlines are in IST.

Tips to finish strong

- Keep your idea small. One feature that works beats five that don't.
- Deploy on Vultr by Saturday evening, not in the last hour.
- Test your live link in a private browser window before you submit.
- Submit at least an hour before the 12:00 IST deadline on Sunday.

Judging and prizes

HackGlobal has a total prize pool of $15,000, including $2,500 in cash and $2,500 in cool tech gadgets, plus credits and more.

What judges look for

- **Merit:** how well the project solves a real problem, and the quality of the build
- **Reach:** real users you reached, plus likes, shares and votes on your project
- **Bonus points:** cross-university teams, pre-event challenges, community participation

Prize rules

- Each team can win only one prize, either a placement or one special award.
- Internship opportunities are separate, and any team can get one.

Demo Day

Six finalist teams present live on Demo Day, Sun 15 Nov, 21:30 to 23:30 IST. Each team gets 7 minutes to present, plus 1 minute of questions from the judges. Winners are announced at the end of the stream.

Optional: LinkedIn idea contest

Post your HackGlobal idea on LinkedIn and tag Polaris School of Technology for a chance to win AirPods. It's individual and fully optional. Skipping it doesn't affect your HackGlobal participation or judging.

Post format and deadline: shared on Discord.

Win while you build

You earn points on Discord for being active: introducing yourself, chatting, sharing your progress and joining sessions. Top members win rewards. We also run fun contests on Discord and the live stream through the weekend.

Rewards and contest list: shared on Discord.

Rules and code of conduct

- Build your project during the hackathon, starting at 00:00 IST on 14 November. You can plan ideas and designs before, but projects built before the start are not valid submissions.
- Use any language or stack. Open-source libraries, APIs and the starter kit are allowed. Credit what you use in your README.
- AI coding tools are allowed, but your project must be your team's own work. Copied, reused or pre-built projects will be disqualified, with or without AI.
- No plagiarism or copied projects. Projects found copied will be disqualified.
- You own what you build.
- Be respectful to everyone. Harassment of any kind is not tolerated.

To report a problem, message an organizer on Discord or email events@polariscampus.com.

By taking part, you agree to follow the rules in the Discord server and a general hackathon code of conduct: be respectful, be honest, and help keep HackGlobal safe and welcoming for everyone.

FAQ

Can I take part without a technical background? Yes. Designers, product thinkers and domain experts are welcome.

Can I build solo? Yes, solo participation is allowed.

How big can my team be? Teams can have 1 to 5 members.

Which tech stack can I use? Any language, framework or tool. Deploy your project on Vultr.

I'm in a different time zone. Will I miss things? No. The website schedule shows every session in your local time, and the kickoff is replayed on Sat 14 Nov, 05:40 to 07:30 IST.

Where do I submit my project? On the HackGlobal page on Vultr Community, from 15 November. Not on HackCulture.

My teammate dropped out. What now? You can continue with fewer members. Let an organizer know on Discord.

Do I get a certificate? Yes. Everyone who submits a project gets a certificate.

Contact

- Discord: the help-desk channel on HackGlobal 2026
- Email: events@polariscampus.com
- Website: hackglobal.polariscampus.com